

ResearchFORCE

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Submission Templates

Abstracts • Scientific Posters • 3-Minute Thesis (3MT) Summaries

A guideline pack for researchers, innovators, and product developers

How to use this pack

This document contains three independent submission templates. Each template begins with a checklist of formatting rules, followed by labelled fields and shaded fill-in boxes you can type directly into. Italic grey text inside boxes is placeholder guidance — replace it with your own content.

The templates follow widely accepted academic conventions:

- Abstracts use the IMRaD structure (Introduction, Methods, Results, Discussion/Conclusion), the standard required by most journals indexed in PubMed, Scopus and Web of Science.
- Scientific posters use the layout recommended by the NIH and the American Medical Writers Association — a single-glance title bar, a left-to-right reading flow, and a clear visual hierarchy.
- 3MT summaries follow the rules of the Three Minute Thesis® competition, originally developed by The University of Queensland in 2008 and now run in more than 900 universities worldwide.

Delete the instructional pages before submitting if your venue asks for the content only.

TEMPLATE 1

Research Abstract

Structured (IMRaD) format — 200 to 300 words

About this format

A research abstract is a self-contained summary of a study, written so that a reader can grasp the question, the approach, the findings and the significance without reading the full paper. The structured format below is the convention adopted by the International Committee of Medical Journal Editors (ICMJE) and is used by the vast majority of life-science and engineering journals.

Formatting checklist

- Word count: 200–300 words (do not include the title, authors or keywords in the count).
- One paragraph per heading, or a single paragraph with bold headings inline — follow your venue's rule.
- Write in the past tense for what you did and the present tense for established facts.
- Avoid abbreviations, citations and figures inside the abstract.
- Numerical results should include units and, where relevant, a measure of variability (SD, 95% CI) and a p-value or effect size.
- 3 to 6 keywords, lower-case, separated by commas, listed in order of importance.

Abstract — fill in below

Title Concise, specific, ≤ 20 words. Avoid jargon, abbreviations, and question marks.

Type the title of your study here.

Authors Full names. Use superscript numbers to link each author to an affiliation.

First A. Author¹, Second B. Author², Third C. Author¹

Affiliations Department, Institution, City, Country — one per line.

¹ Department of ..., University of ..., City, Country

Corresponding author Name and institutional email.

Name, email@institution.edu

Background

1–2 sentences setting the scientific context and the gap your study addresses.

Why does this problem matter, and what is currently unknown?

Objective / Aim

1 sentence stating the precise research question or hypothesis.

This study aimed to ...

Methods

2–4 sentences on study design, setting, participants/samples, key measurements, and the main analysis.

Describe design, sample, materials and analytic approach.

Results

2–4 sentences reporting the principal findings with numerical estimates and variability/significance.

Report the main outcome(s) with quantitative detail.

Conclusion

1–2 sentences stating what the results mean and the implication for practice, policy or further research.

State the take-home message and its significance.

Keywords 3–6 terms, comma-separated.

keyword 1, keyword 2, keyword 3, keyword 4

Conflict of interest *If none, write "The authors declare no conflict of interest."*

Disclose any financial or personal relationships that could bias the work.

Funding source *Name the funder and grant number, or write "None."*

This work was supported by ...

TEMPLATE 2

Scientific Poster

Content blueprint for an A0 / A1 conference poster

About this format

A scientific poster is a single-page visual summary of a study, designed to be read at arm's length and to spark conversation with the author. This template provides the textual content for each standard panel — you will paste the finished text into your poster software (PowerPoint, Keynote, Illustrator, Canva, Inkscape, or LaTeX/Beamer) at A0 (841 × 1189 mm) or A1 (594 × 841 mm).

Design checklist

- Orientation: portrait or landscape — follow the conference rule. If unspecified, portrait is most common.
- Reading flow: top-to-bottom, left-to-right, in three or four columns.
- Font sizes (when printed at A0): title ≥ 72 pt; section headings 36–48 pt; body text 24–32 pt; captions 18–24 pt.
- Word budget: aim for 300–800 words across the whole poster. Less text, more figures.
- Figures and tables should occupy 40–60% of the area. Every figure needs a self-explanatory caption.
- Use a consistent colour palette (3–4 colours) and a sans-serif body font (Arial, Helvetica, Calibri, Lato).
- Ensure colour-blind safe palettes — avoid red/green contrasts; check with a simulator before printing.

Poster content — fill in below

Header block (top of poster)

Poster title ≤ 15 words. Should communicate the finding, not just the topic.

e.g. "A novel low-cost biosensor improves early detection of ..."

Authors Presenting author underlined or marked with an asterisk.

A. Author, B. Author, C. Author*

Affiliations & logos Departments, institutions, funders.

¹ Institution, City, Country • ² Institution, City, Country

Body panels

A typical layout. Replace placeholder text with your content.

1. Introduction / Background 50–100 words. Set the scene; state the gap.

What is known? What is unknown? Why does it matter now?

2. Aim / Research question / Hypothesis 1–2 sentences.

We hypothesised that ...

3. Materials & Methods 80–150 words. Diagrams of workflow are better than prose.

Design • Sample • Procedure • Analysis. Consider a flowchart.

4. Results Largest panel. Figures + 1–2 sentence captions. Minimal narrative.

Figure 1. [Self-contained caption: what the figure shows and the key finding.]

5. Discussion 80–150 words. What do the results mean? Limitations?

Interpret findings, compare with prior work, acknowledge limits.

6. Conclusions Bullet points, ideally 3.

• Finding 1 • Finding 2 • Implication / next step

Footer block (bottom of poster)

References Key citations only — usually 3 to 6, in a small font.

1. Author A, et al. Journal Year;Vol:pp.

Acknowledgments Funders, participants, technical staff.

This work was supported by ... We thank ... for ...

Contact / QR code Email of presenting author and an optional QR linking to a full PDF or pre-print.

name@institution.edu • ORCID • QR code placeholder

TEMPLATE 3

Three Minute Thesis (3MT®) Summary

A spoken-script and single-slide research pitch

About this format

The Three Minute Thesis (3MT®) is an academic communication competition developed by The University of Queensland in 2008. Researchers must explain their research and its significance to a non-specialist audience in three minutes or less, using only one static slide. The challenge is not to simplify the science to the point of inaccuracy, but to find a story-arc that a curious general reader can follow.

Official competition rules (UQ 3MT®)

- A single static PowerPoint slide is permitted. No slide transitions, animations, or movement of any kind. The slide is to be presented from the beginning of the oration.
- No additional electronic media (e.g. sound and video files) are permitted.
- No additional props (e.g. costumes, musical instruments, laboratory equipment) are permitted.
- Presentations are limited to 3 minutes maximum; competitors exceeding 3 minutes are disqualified.
- Presentations are to be spoken word (e.g. no poems, raps or songs).
- Presentations are to commence from the stage.
- Presentations are considered to have commenced when a presenter starts their presentation through either movement or speech.
- The decision of the adjudicating panel is final.

Pacing and word budget

A natural speaking rate is 120–150 words per minute, which means a 3-minute talk corresponds to roughly 360–450 written words. Aim for the lower end to leave room for pauses and audience reactions.

3MT summary — fill in below

Presentation title *Catchy, jargon-free, ≤ 12 words. Often a question or a statement of impact.*

e.g. "How a fungus could clean our rivers in a week."

Presenter *Full name.*

Discipline / Faculty

Principal supervisor

Single-slide description *Describe the one static image you will project. Often a single photograph, diagram or metaphor.*

Describe the image, what it shows, and why it supports your story.

The 3-minute script (≈ 350–450 words)

Use the seven beats below. Write in plain English — imagine you are explaining your work to a smart 12-year-old, a family member at dinner, or a stranger on a train.

1. The Hook (≈ 30 sec, 50–75 words) *Open with a question, a startling statistic, a vivid scenario, or a relatable analogy. Earn the audience's attention before you ask for it.*

Imagine if ... / Did you know that ... / Last year, ...

2. The Problem (≈ 30 sec, 50–75 words) *Why does this matter? Whose life, environment or industry is affected?*

Today, ... people are affected by ...

3. The Gap (≈ 20 sec, 30–50 words) *What can current approaches not do? Where does existing science fall short?*

Until now, scientists could only ...

4. Your Research Question / Aim (≈ 15 sec, 20–35 words) *State it as a single sentence in everyday language.*

My research asks: ...

5. What You Did — Methods in plain English (≈ 30 sec, 50–75 words) *Use analogies. Avoid acronyms. Skip the apparatus.*

Think of my approach as ... I ... then ...

6. What You Found / Expect (≈ 30 sec, 50–75 words) *The one or two findings the audience should remember.*

What I discovered is ...

7. So What? — Impact & closing (≈ 25 sec, 40–60 words) *Tie back to the hook. End with a memorable, forward-looking line.*

This means ... and in five years could ...

Self-check before submitting

- Read it aloud and time it. If it runs over 2:55, cut — do not speed up.
- Remove every acronym, every Greek letter, every measurement unit you can replace with a comparison.
- Ask a non-specialist friend to repeat back what your research is about. Iterate until they get it on the first listen.
- Practise standing still. Movement competes with your slide for attention.

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